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March 14, 2025

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Vanta Response to the “Development of an AI Action Plan” Request for Information (RFI)

For the United States to maintain its global leadership in the development and adoption of Artificial Intelligence (AI), it must create an actionable roadmap for acceleration. Vanta strongly supports the Office of Science and Technology Policy’s (OSTP) [initiative](#) to “define the priority policy actions needed to sustain and enhance America's AI dominance, and to ensure that unnecessarily burdensome requirements do not hamper private sector AI innovation,” and believes that the creation of an AI Action Plan will be a critical step in this endeavor.

Although we are still in the early stages of AI adoption, the efficiency and effectiveness gains from AI – and what broad AI use means for the future of U.S. economic prosperity, national security, and human flourishing – are clear. The development and deployment of AI has the potential to unlock widespread, transformational benefits for the U.S. and its government, private sector, society, and citizens. And importantly, the effective adoption of AI for national security – including in the protection of critical infrastructure and American industry – will be necessary to ensure that the U.S. remains ahead of its global competitors.

At the same time, the technological breakthroughs of China-based AI companies like DeepSeek are strong reminders that the continuation of U.S. global leadership in AI is both imperative, but not assured. America’s adversaries are working diligently to overcome our AI advantage, both by accelerating their own technological advancements, and by seeking to undermine the foundations of America’s own innovation community and critical systems.

Fortunately, the United States has a key advantage: It is the home of the world’s greatest innovators, technologists, and visionaries, all operating within the global beacon of capitalism. America has demonstrated, time and again, that when faced with era-defining challenges and opportunities, government and industry can mobilize for success.

As a U.S.-based software company that builds and deploys AI systems to help over 10,000 organizations – of all sizes and sectors – create, orchestrate, monitor, maintain, and demonstrate their overall security and data privacy programs, Vanta can provide a unique and experience-based perspective to help inform the creation of a U.S. AI Action Plan. Vanta’s own AI-powered platform is designed to simplify and streamline the orchestration, management, and automation of security programs tied to over 35 security frameworks, including AI-related frameworks like the NIST AI Risk Management Framework and ISO 42001. Given this experience, we feel both capable and proud to share our feedback below.

Accelerate Government Adoption of Artificial Intelligence

The swift and large-scale adoption of advanced technologies, inclusive of AI, by the U.S. government is essential to defending and promoting American prosperity. While technology modernization across the federal government has long been recognized as necessary, the government’s ability to rapidly procure, adopt, and field new commercial technologies has not met the pace and scope of mission needs. This is especially true in the case of AI and AI-enabled software, where the government has the opportunity to leverage these technologies to increase the efficiency of a more nimble government workforce. Yet government procurement remains constrained by complex processes that rely on time-consuming, manual workflows. For example, Authority to Operate (ATO) processes – by which agencies evaluate and verify that commercial technologies meet the security requirements for agency use – are backlogged under the weight of demand and the lack of modern tooling that are designed to unlock efficiencies.

At the same time, we are in an era where both government and industry are facing constant cybersecurity threats from America’s adversaries. As such, agencies must address both the expediency needs of modernization, as well as demands for security and transparency in the tools they are adopting. The Administration is right to consider: *How can government speed up and scale the procurement of AI-enabled technologies in support of agency missions, while ensuring the security of the technologies being adopted?*

Policy Recommendations

- (1) *FedRAMP Reform.* The FedRAMP Program Management Office (PMO) within the General Services Administration is responsible for the important task of evaluating and authorizing the security of cloud-based software for government use – and most AI tools are, and should be, cloud-based. However, the FedRAMP authorization process itself has become a barrier to rapid technology adoption. Due to unclear security requirements, challenging coordination between multiple authorizing offices (each with their own niche requirements that are difficult to anticipate), and long wait times as evaluators manually process reviews, the main

entry-point for cloud-based, AI-enabled technology would benefit from reform. We recommend that:

- (a) Agency sponsorship be eliminated as the main pathway and requirement for FedRAMP authorization. The requirement that most FedRAMP applications include an agency sponsor creates added complexity without clear security benefits, while also privileging well-connected and established businesses that have close government contacts (creating severe disadvantages for America's innovative and world-leading startup community).
 - (b) FedRAMP PMO itself could and should be using more AI-enabled software to make the evaluation and continuous monitoring of security systems seamless and fast, reducing barriers to adoption. As such, the FedRAMP PMO should be provided the mandate and resources to accelerate the adoption of existing, commercially-available software that can help program officers streamline and automate the authorization process without sacrificing substantive security verification.
- (2) *Authority to Operate Reciprocity.* The requirement that commercial technologies must receive unique ATOs from each procuring agency not only slows down government acquisition of new technologies, it also places an immense burden on small and medium-sized business (SMBs) and non-traditional firms that have fewer resources to wade through multiple, redundant regulatory hurdles. While different agencies will have additional specific security requirements to meet their unique mission needs, reform towards greater ATO reciprocity is both necessary and feasible with advanced automation tools. Once there is greater uniformity and harmonization across ATO programs, agency buyers and AI technology providers will be able to focus more intently and efficiently on the agency-specific security requirements that matter.
- (3) *Use of Advanced Procurement Tools.* Federal agencies should invest in technologies that streamline the process of evaluating third-party vendor risk, as well as verifying (and continuously monitoring) the security compliance of government vendors. AI vendors, procurement officers, and authorizing agents alike can leverage AI-enabled, commercially-available procurement and vendor-risk management platforms to create a simplified and centralized security verification process. These tools can accelerate the security review process, automate the more manual aspects of the ATO lifecycle, and ensure continuous

compliance with security requirements, ultimately allowing government procurement officers and cybersecurity professionals the ability to do more with the resources they have available.

- (4) *Trusted GovTech Marketplaces*. Beyond the GSA Schedule and FedRAMP Marketplace, agencies should experiment with the creation of “trusted marketplaces” where previously vetted and verified commercial technologies can be available for rapid procurement and adoption. For example, the DoD Chief Digital and Artificial Intelligence Office (CDAO) has demonstrated early promise in these types of initiatives through the [Tradewinds](#) and [OpenDAGIR](#) programs. With the help of AI-enabled workflows, marketplaces can also accelerate technology procurement by mapping program requirements with vendor capabilities and costs, as well as matching mission needs and risk-tolerances with the risk posture of available capabilities. Furthermore, such marketplaces can be equipped with AI-enabled continuous monitoring / continuous ATO capabilities to ensure that commercially available solutions on the marketplace are meeting the requisite security standards at all times.

Enhance Competition and Innovation by Removing Unnecessary Barriers and Improving Incentives

Competition within the U.S. innovation economy has led directly to the world-leading AI advancements we see today and anticipate in the future. As President Trump’s policies recognize, encouraging and enhancing competition in the U.S. technology sector are critical to America’s long term success by incentivizing the private sector to make large-scale, high-risk investments in frontier technologies like AI. To fuel America’s AI innovation engine and stay ahead of its rivals, U.S. AI policies should strive to remove unnecessary barriers to industry-led innovation and promote conditions that will allow America’s innovators to thrive.

For example, we find that one of the biggest obstacles commercial innovators face – particularly for startups and small businesses – is the difficulty of managing a complex multitude of regulatory regimes that in some domains are simultaneously strict and inconsistent, and in others wholly redundant. This creates unnecessary burdens on smaller, innovative businesses who cannot afford to spend their way through uncertainty as they pursue a moving target of regulatory compliance, and ultimately creates an unfair advantage for larger enterprises who have the resources to meet these challenges.

Promoting greater competition within the commercial innovation sector is highly compatible with the recommendations above to accelerate the U.S. government’s adoption of AI

technologies. First, the U.S. government cannot benefit from the adoption of new, world-leading technologies if American innovation is hindered. And second, enabling robust competition and consumer choice will allow the U.S. government to take advantage of the best and most cost-effective technologies, while also guarding against the types of vendor lock-in that impede government efficiency and responsible stewardship of taxpayer resources.

Policy Recommendations

- (1) *Foster Competition Among Providers.* We encourage the Administration to continue its rigorous pursuit to ensure competitive AI innovation markets. Greater competition within the AI ecosystem will give federal agencies (and commercial consumers) more variety and choice in the AI tools and technologies they adopt, which in turn will encourage AI developers and deployers to take product security and effectiveness, data transparency, and consumer trust more seriously.
- (2) *Streamline and Harmonize Standards.* The Administration should support executive and legislative efforts to substantially streamline, harmonize, and simplify federal regulations in order to limit unnecessary burdens on industry innovators. To facilitate and inform this effort, the Department of Commerce and NIST should make a public Request for Information to solicit feedback directly from industry and other impacted organizations.
- (3) *Tax Incentives for Innovation Risk-Takers.* We additionally encourage the government to reduce barriers to investment in earlier-stage AI initiatives. For example, the government can expand tax breaks for founders and early founding teams (e.g., Qualified Small Business Stock), as well as reform outdated and complex tax regulations (e.g., 26 U.S. Code § 409a and 422) to incentivize Americans to join pre-IPO companies with favorable tax treatment on equity stakes in those businesses.
- (4) *Buy Commercial, Buy American.* Making the government market more accessible to the private sector – including AI innovators – is necessary to enable the sustained growth of cutting-edge technologies, but importantly, to also ensure that the U.S. government is utilizing the most advanced technologies available. To ensure that agencies are maximizing the benefits of the domestic commercial software market, we recommend the Administration prioritize the enforcement of FAR Part 12 and 41 U.S. Code § 3307 for government procurement and acquisitions.

Building Transparency and Trust to Accelerate AI Innovation and Adoption

Across the entire AI lifecycle, trust is an accelerant of AI innovation and adoption. Creators of AI-enabled platforms and model deployers must trust that model developers are rigorously adhering to test and evaluation (T&E) best practices, ensuring their models are secure and behave as advertised. Developers must trust that deployers are using their models appropriately, including that they are deployed with security in mind. Importantly, the American consumer must trust in the effectiveness of the products they are using, while also being assured that their data is being handled with respect to consumer privacy and security.

We believe that when higher levels of trust exist between all actors in the AI ecosystem, both innovation and adoption rates will accelerate. Trust across the AI ecosystem remains understandably low because – like most domains – trust must be built, demonstrated, and sustained over time.

To build greater trust and accelerate AI adoption, we recommend an examination of market-based incentives for transparency and accountability across the entire AI ecosystem, without the imposition of regulatory regimes that may limit innovation.

Policy Recommendations

- (1) *Shared Responsibility Models.* Encourage commercial AI developers and deployers to collaborate on the adoption of industry-led shared responsibility models, geared towards clarifying which actors are responsible for what aspects of AI system security. Shared responsibility models not only provide transparency and accountability across the AI ecosystem, they also help ensure more complete coverage of AI risk across entire systems and their full lifecycle. For an example, see [Microsoft's](#) “AI Shared Responsibility Model.”
- (2) *Consumer Rights.* Most often, “Terms and Conditions” are designed to be inherently vague (or only intelligible to lawyers), making it difficult for consumers across the AI ecosystem to understand what technology they are using and its implications. As such, leading AI developers and deployers should be encouraged to publicize straightforward and accessible “Terms and Conditions of Service” for their offerings (in plain language), with clear descriptions around: (a) What underlying technology and models are being used; (b) What information a given system is storing; and (c) How data generated for and by AI models will be used and managed. Let AI developers compete based on the features, functionality, and value propositions they deliver to consumers in full transparency of how they are behaving.

Cybersecurity & Protecting America's AI Supply Chain

To sustain America's global leadership in AI, the U.S. not only needs to drive positive innovation, but also excel at identifying and defeating threats against its advancement. This includes America's ability to secure every component of the AI lifecycle and supply chains. From chip designs, to semiconductor fabrication facilities, to training data, to deployer intellectual property, to end-user personally identifying information, the surface area of cybersecurity risk for any given AI system is immense.

Ensuring that actors within the AI ecosystem remain vigilant around managing their own cybersecurity risk, as well as those of their vendors and suppliers, will be of critical importance. While this task is equally necessary for large and small actors within the AI ecosystem alike, the costs and complexity of maintaining an elevated cybersecurity posture can be prohibitive for innovative, smaller companies that cannot benefit from scale.

As such, any policies that seek to elevate the cybersecurity posture of AI supply chains must account for every actor and supplier type, including the potential provision of programming and resources to ensure that SMBs are able to meet the requisite security standards.

Policy Recommendations

- (1) *AI Supply Chain Threat Assessment.* Instruct the Department of Commerce and Department of Homeland Security to conduct a study of cybersecurity risks and vulnerabilities to critical AI infrastructure and supply chains, as well as to provide actionable recommendations on how government and industry can overcome existing gaps.
- (2) *Promote Continuous Security Monitoring.* Promote continuous supply chain risk management across the entire AI ecosystem to ensure that organizations – both within government and industry – can verify the security postures of third-party vendors being brought into their AI supply chains, without slowing down the pace of partnership and cross-industry innovation.
- (3) *Secure AI Innovators.* The U.S. innovation sector can and should be treated as critical infrastructure. While the government should continue to find new opportunities for cybersecurity collaboration across the entire AI industry ecosystem, it is especially important that the Administration identifies opportunities to provide increased programmatic resourcing and direct funding to those that need it most – small and medium-sized businesses.

Conclusion

Safeguarding America’s global leadership in AI requires an action plan. We commend the Trump Administration for driving this initiative, as well for soliciting the perspective of the public.

As argued above, we believe that policies which create an incentives- and competition-based environment for AI advancement – as well as build greater trust and transparency across the AI ecosystem – will spur innovation and accelerate adoption.

Vanta [supports](#) “the policy of the United States to sustain and enhance America's global AI dominance in order to promote human flourishing, economic competitiveness, and national security,” and we appreciate the opportunity to share our expertise and perspective in this critical endeavor to create an AI Action Plan. We stand ready to provide any further clarification as needed.

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